to be practised in Soviet Russia, looked savage and totally alien to most people in the rest of Europe. For outsiders, it certainly added to their perceptions of the 'otherness' of Eastern Europe.

But it was not only about a fundamental change of governance *within* Russia itself. The new and quite unique feature was the Soviet ambition to transform the rest of Europe (and the world). That was the intention of the Soviet Communists from the very beginning: 'From the outset Communist parties were established across the globe and financed with vast sums of Russian money. […] The customary forms of international relations were thus systematically overturned by Moscow's messianic commitment to overturning the established international order at all costs and as soon as practicable.' To that end, as early as 1919 the Soviets launched the Comintern, a semi-official agency tasked with coordinating Communist parties abroad and fomenting revolutions. So important was the export of the revolution to Lenin that he 'poured millions of dollars into the furthering of unrest worldwide – even while his own population in the south was driven to cannibalism in 1921.' [41]

There has been much debate as to why Communism took roots in Russia first. Some say that the Russian (and more generally the Slavic) soul is somehow more susceptible to collectivist ideas and that Russians were for ages used to the iron fist of their Tsars. Much as they detested it, so the argument goes, they also secretly admired it, and it was not difficult to have the Romanov Tsars replaced by a Communist Tsar – Stalin, or much later Putin. The alleged taste of the Orthodox Church for grandeur and for a strong nation-state is also supposed to fit into this picture – there another analogy can certainly be drawn with the Russian Orthodox Church's support for the war in Ukraine. There may also be some weight in the argument that a country as large and sparsely populated as Russia is difficult to govern, and therefore needs a strong centralist government. Anyway, Lenin was smart enough to realise that the utterly impoverished Russian peasantry (and the relatively few industrial workers in the country) would, at least initially, back any change. He also had the support of Germany, which saw benefit in anything that would make Russia weaker. Soon a monstrous totalitarian system was put in place, preceding its Fascist and Nazi counterparts that were soon to follow.

Indeed, the situation was not much different in the other two totalitarian